# Day 14 - Norman Pearson, Eric Best, King, McNally, Smokey Hollow

Bruce Trail side-trail plan (dog-friendly, max ~8 mi) · Iroquoia section · hike 20 · Great Falls (Smokey Hollow), Waterdown

| 10.4 km / 6.5 mi | ~3.2 h | 3.5 km new | 45 min |
|---|---|---|---|
| total walking | hiking, plus stops | side trail covered | drive each way, Sat 7 am |

**Park (P):** Great Falls: Parking area beside Mill St, at the Smokey Hollow Side Trail. Google Maps. **Free**

**Navigate:** import *day14_hike020.gpx* into Gaia GPS. The track is the whole route in walking order, and the J waypoints match the directions below.

**Side trails covered:** Norman Pearson Side Trail (1.4 km); Eric Best Side Trail (1.0 km); King Side Trail (0.6 km); McNally Side Trail (0.5 km); Smokey Hollow Side Trail (0.1 km)

## Route map




## What to expect

- **Parking:** Lot beside Mill St at the Smokey Hollow Side Trail, right by the falls (a trip report describes it as free).
- **Great Falls:** About 10 m high on Grindstone Creek, with an overhanging dolostone cap and remains of an old mill dam and stone abutments. The Smokey Hollow Side Trail leads to a viewing platform above the crest. The creek banks get slippery and icy; stay back from the edge.
- **Main Bruce Trail:** Steps and switchbacks on the Grindstone Creek valley slopes near the falls, and several short road-shoulder stretches (including Flanders Dr); keep Zappy close. A lookout past King Rd gives views of Burlington and Lake Ontario.
- **Norman Pearson and McNally side trails:** The Norman Pearson Side Trail (blue-blazed) runs from level ground on the main trail to Waterdown Rd, including a road stretch. It connects to the McNally Side Trail, which crosses BTC-owned land with a reported overlook of

Burlington Bay and tall trees along the escarpment edge.

- **Eric Best and King side trails:** No specific descriptions were found. Around King Rd the main trail passes through Conservation Halton's Waterdown Woods: a grassy field and mature hardwoods.
- **Private land:** Much of the trail here crosses private property by landowner permission. Stay on the marked trail.

## Parking options

| | Alternative parking | Parking cost | Route km | Walk to trail | Closest side trails |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **P2** | Roadside parking on King Rd map | Free | 4.3 | 0 m | |

**Can't do it all in one go?** Split it into two shorter outings: **Outing 1** from the planned parking (P): 3.8 km / 2.4 mi, covering McNally, Norman Pearson, Smokey Hollow. **Outing 2** from P2 (Roadside parking on King Rd; Free): 7.9 km / 4.9 mi, covering Eric Best, King. The website's map shows which parts are already done.

Parking costs were checked in October 2026 from operator websites and Bruce Trail Conservancy data; prices and booking rules change, so check before you go.

## Turn-by-turn

| km | mi | Directions |
|---|---|---|
| 0.0 | 0.0 | Start at the parking: Great Falls: Parking area beside Mill St, at the Smokey Hollow Side Trail. Head south on the blue-blazed Smokey Hollow Side Trail. |
| 0.1 | 0.0 | J1: Continue straight onto the white-blazed main Bruce Trail, heading south-east. (the white-blazed main Bruce Trail goes off on your left.) |
| 0.8 | 0.5 | J2: Turn left onto the blue-blazed Norman Pearson Side Trail, heading east. (the white-blazed main Bruce Trail goes off ahead.) |
| 1.2 | 0.7 | Heads-up: The next 0.1 km follows an unopened road allowance (rough track, no traffic). |
| 1.3 | 0.8 | Heads-up: The next 0.4 km follows a road shoulder; keep the dog close. |
| 2.1 | 1.3 | J3: Continue straight onto the blue-blazed McNally Side Trail, heading east. (the blue-blazed McNally Side Trail goes off on your left.) |
| 2.3 | 1.4 | J4: End of the McNally Side Trail. Turn around and retrace your steps. |
| 2.4 | 1.5 | J3: Junction. Turn right to stay on the McNally Side Trail, heading north-west. (the Norman Pearson Side Trail you already walked goes off ahead.) |
| 2.8 | 1.7 | J5: Turn right onto the white-blazed main Bruce Trail, heading east. (the white-blazed main Bruce Trail goes off ahead.) |
| 4.8 | 3.0 | J6: Turn left onto the blue-blazed King Side Trail, heading north. (the white-blazed main Bruce Trail goes off ahead.) |
| 5.4 | 3.4 | J7: Turnaround point. Turn around and retrace your steps. |
| 6.0 | 3.7 | J6: Turn right onto the white-blazed main Bruce Trail, heading south-west. (the white-blazed main Bruce Trail goes off on your left.) |
| 8.1 | 5.0 | J5: Junction. Turn right to stay on the main Bruce Trail, heading north-west. (the McNally Side Trail you already walked goes off on your left.) |
| 8.2 | 5.1 | Heads-up: The next 0.4 km follows a road shoulder; keep the dog close. |
| 8.7 | 5.4 | J8: Turn right onto the blue-blazed Eric Best Side Trail, heading south. (the white-blazed main Bruce Trail goes off on your left.) |
| 9.0 | 5.6 | J9: Start the Eric Best Side Trail loop (0.6 km). Continue straight onto it, heading north-east; it brings you back to this junction. |
| 10.0 | 6.2 | J8: Turn right onto the white-blazed main Bruce Trail, heading east. (the main Bruce Trail you already walked goes off on your left.) |
| 10.4 | 6.4 | J1: Turn right onto the blue-blazed Smokey Hollow Side Trail, heading north-west. (the main Bruce Trail you already walked goes off on your left.) |
| 10.4 | 6.5 | Back at the parking. Hike complete. |

Distances and junctions are computed from the Bruce Trail Conservancy's trail data (Bruce County GIS). Left/right is calculated from the trail geometry. Use it as a guide, follow the blazes, and check the Conservancy's trail-change notices before you go. Dogs must be leashed everywhere on the Bruce Trail. Trail descriptions draw on Hiking the GTA, Ontario Nature Trails and a 2015 Bruce Trail trip report.